

BEFORE

The Turkish tribes that founded the Ottoman Empire were originally semi-nomadic farmers who inhabited the steppes of Central Asia.

THE TURKS

Turkish tribes made early contact with the Islamic world through trade, warfare, and missionaries. They were also used as **slave warriors** by the **Abbasid caliphate** << 174–75—the Islamic empire based in Baghdad—which led to the conversion of the Turks to Islam. The Ottoman lands in Anatolia bordered wealthy non-Muslim areas, which brought opportunities for expansion.

ANATOLIA

Before the influx of the Muslim Turkish tribes, Anatolia was ruled by the **Byzantine Empire** << 198–99. It was inhabited mainly by small communities of settled Greek Christian farmers, interspersed with larger towns such as Nicaea (now the city of Iznik in Turkey).



Seljuk soldiers

This 13th-century stone relief depicts the armored warriors who maintained Seljuk power. The Seljuks were a Sunni Muslim dynasty that ruled parts of Central Asia and the Middle East in the 11th–14th centuries.

The Rise of Ottoman Power

The Ottoman Empire was founded by a small group of nomadic Turkish warriors in Anatolia (modern-day Turkey). It lasted for 700 years, becoming a vast empire whose power and influence spanned the globe.

In the 10th century, the caliphate based in Baghdad (see pp.174–77) began to fragment into separate political entities, until it controlled only the provinces immediately around it. At the end of the 10th century, the remains of the caliphate were conquered by Turkish tribes from Central Asia. The Seljuk family who led the tribes took power as *sultans* (from the Turkish word for “authority”), restoring political authority to the caliphate, while exercising real power themselves through the figurehead caliphs. Although the Seljuks took over the existing system of government, their power was inherently unstable as it relied heavily on their nomadic warriors, who frequently clashed with settled peoples.

In 1071, the Seljuks defeated the Byzantine emperor in eastern Anatolia, and Byzantine rule was replaced by that of the Rum Seljuks, who were a

branch of the Seljuk dynasty. This, and the fact Anatolia was well suited to the way of life practiced by the Turks, led to an influx of semi-nomadic tribes.

Disintegration

Another group of nomadic peoples from Central Asia were the Mongols (pp.204–05), who invaded most of Asia and parts of Europe. By 1258, the invading Mongol army had conquered most of Anatolia, Iran, and Iraq, replacing the Seljuks with the Ilkhanid dynasty (from the Mongol word for leader, *khan*). The Turks in Anatolia were forced to move westward into areas previously ruled by the Byzantines.

The Ilkhanid hold over Anatolia was never strong, and the peninsula soon began to disintegrate into multiple tribes and principalities. One of these small groups was led by Osman, son of Ertughrul, after whom the Ottoman Empire was named. This



Ottoman war helmet

This battle helmet dates from c. 1500. Technological advances in warfare gave the Ottomans an edge in battle.

Finding a barrier blocking the route to the estuary on one side of Constantinople, the Ottomans dragged their ships overland to surround the city.

group was located in a strategically important area controlling the approach to Constantinople from the east. From here, the Ottomans managed to take over many Byzantine cities in Anatolia, which brought them more wealth and resources. The Ottomans then annexed land along the Dardanelles, which allowed them to control the crossing to Europe.

The creation of an empire

In the mid-14th century, the Ottomans aided the Byzantine emperor John VI Kantakouzenos in a civil war, and were rewarded with their first lands in Europe, on the Gallipoli peninsula. At the same time, the Ottomans expanded their lands in central and western Anatolia. After this, they spread into Europe, moving through eastern Thrace and across the Balkans. It was then that they probably encountered artillery for the first time.



KEY

- Nucleus of Ottoman Empire c. 1300
- Conquests of Osman I, c. 1300–26
- Conquests of Orkhan I, c. 1326–62
- Conquests of Murad I, c. 1362–89
- Conquests of Bayezid I, c. 1389–1402
- Further Ottoman conquest by 1481
- Vassal of Ottoman Empire by 1481
- Under Venetian control c. 1450
- Siege

Ottoman Empire

The Ottoman Empire was very extensive until the end of the 15th century. At the center was Constantinople, whose fall to the Ottomans in 1453 is shown opposite. Its central location made its capture essential if the Ottomans were to rule in both Asia and Europe successfully.

